

T. NAGAR

Saidapet » West Mambalam » Vadapalani » Porur » Kattupakkam » Irungattukottai » Nungambakkam » Manapakkam » Ashok Nagar » Valasaravakkam
Gerugambakkam » Mangadu » Choolaimedu » Egmore » K K Nagar » Kodambakkam » Virugambakkam » Somangalam » Poonamalee » Chetpet

Sidewalks 'vanish' at Mambalam High Road

Blocked footpaths on this major road which lies in Teynampet zone of Greater Chennai Corporation compel pedestrians to share the carriageway with motorists



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Pedestrians walking down Mambalam High Road, starting from Duraisamy Subway to Kodambakkam Railway Station, are at the mercy of motorists. The walking area, including the pavement, is out of bounds for pedestrians who have therefore requested Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) to reclaim the space for them. This road

comes under Zone 9 of GCC.

These areas are used for parking abandoned vehicles, dumping construction debris and trash, and even as a washroom.

K. Inbamathi, a resident, says, "This situation has been prevailing for years; pedestrians are forced to walk on the carriageway amidst traffic, and there are no speed breakers. During rains, walking on this stretch becomes a huge challenge."

The same situation persists along Bazullah Road and Gandhi Street. Carelessly flung liquor bottles add to pedestrians' discomfort.

Along Bazullah Road, railway equipment have been lying for years, making it easy for people to relieve themselves and indulge in anti-social activities. Near Ramachandra Street, people have left trash in the walkway despite the presence of garbage bins.

Along Chari Street, the walking

The sidewalks at Mambalam High Road along Kodambakkam Railway Station are out of bounds for pedestrians. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

area is strewn with construction debris for many days now, posing great inconvenience to walkers, residents point out.

Further, along the stretch, commercial establishments encroach upon the pavements, turning the

walkway into a parking lot. The same situation prevails along Vivekananda Street and Ramakrishna Street.

Near Kodambakkam Railway Station, the walkway is no less than a parking lot.

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‘Grey water discharge in incomplete SWD’



P. SENTHIL KUMAR

The stormwater drain construction at EVP Park Avenue in Iyyappanthangal began last May but it remains incomplete to this day. The remaining work involves linking the drain to the existing drain network which carries water which it drains into the Cooum river in Vanagaram.

Both ends of the drain are not connected. While one end is at EVP Park Avenue, the other end is at Pillayarmadathangal Salai (better known as Krishna Nagar Main Road) in Noombal under Thiruverkadu Municipality.

To make things worse, residents have started to misuse the incomplete drain to discharge



The drain at Noombal; and (right) at Iyyappanthangal and (below) the grey water overflow.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

grey water resulting in overflows on the road. This problem is witnessed at the Iyyappanthangal end because it is low-lying. There is a school here. But the stretch is slushy and dirty.

It may be noted there are gradient flaws at the Iyyappanthangal

section of the SWD. That also needs to be addressed; otherwise, linking of the drain will not serve the purpose.

Complaints to the authorities concerned have gone in vain.

P. Senthil Kumar is a resident of Iyyappanthangal

Two things that need fixing



The images of pavement railings are from a section of Langs Garden Road. One shows a railing that is bent and has partially collapsed, a portion jutting into the carriageway. It is twisted out of shape, suggesting it was hit with force likely by a vehicle. The piece of public infrastructure is left in a dysfunctional state. From Harris Road, the third image shows a small broken patch of asphalt, from which two thick cables or conduits jut upward at an angle, one bent like a hooked finger and the other leaning slightly. Around their base, the surface is rough. One rider swerving suddenly to avoid this could trigger collisions in a tightly packed traffic flow. If these are electrical conduits and not fully insulated, rainwater pooling could create an electrocution hazard, rare but possible.

PHOTOS: RAGU R

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‘Cattle movement compromises safety on Bharaniputhur Road’

S. SANTHOSH

Roaming of stray cattle is a common sight on Bharaniputhur Road at Koluthuvanchery, a neighbourhood in Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat. They roam on the roads disrupting traffic; this is a serious concern.

This is a narrow road with many bends. Further, this road is a busy one as it provides connectivity to Mount-Poonmallee High Road and Perungalathur-Puzhal Chennai Bypass. Therefore, cattle movement on this road raises the risk of accidents. It may be noted dumping of garbage along the road fuels this problem. While Greater Chennai Corporation recently introduced guidelines to prevent roaming of cattle on public roads there are no such regulations for panchayats.

GCC has mandated that every cattle reared within its limits be registered and implanted with micro-



Cattle on Bharaniputhur Road in Koluthuvanchery.

chips containing ownership details such as name and address and relevant animal details. Cattle owners are expected to obtain licenses. All

these are aimed at curbing cattle movement on public roads and to identify repeated offenders. I request the authorities that such

measures should be implemented in panchayats too.

S. Santhosh is a resident of Iyyappanthangal

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Learning need not be constrained by age. While that thinking could ring resoundingly true on paper, on the ground, it could be challenged by practical difficulties, particularly where the learning has to be structured, sustained and requires external support.

There are no such constraints on the ground, well floor, for senior citizens at Valasaravakkam centre of Akshaya Trust. At this free old age home, seniors are learning to dance, thanks to Raack Academy of Dance. Recently, senior choreographer B. Pradeep Prasad led a session for these seniors.

The two-hour free workshop started with old Tamil songs, especially MGR hits and moved to other simple dance moves. Pradeep, who heads the Ramapuram centre of the Academy, plans to visit the home for senior citizens more frequently and keep the momentum going. “I plan to conduct these simple dance workshops once in two months as it can help improve their mobility and posture,” says Pradeep.

Dance benefits people across age groups in many ways. Previously, Pradeep conducted classes for students of a school for the blind and those on the spectrum. “This free workshop is our small



Happy feet at old age home

Seniors at this Valasaravakkam facility run by Akshaya Trust get to attend dance classes

way of spreading the benefits of dance,” he says.

The branch has close to 40 seniors in the age group of 65 to 89 years, with a majority enrolled in to the centre as they have none to take care of them.

“We only had a small number of them who took part in this first workshop and I am hoping in the next class more would join and would want to be part of the sessions that would follow,” says Bhuvaneswari Elangovan, gener-

al manager, Akshaya Trust.

She says the Trust runs six old age homes in Chennai and one in Arapakkam, and they welcome interested groups to spend their time with seniors.

Last month, they had students of Sri Annai Kamakshi Music and Fine Arts College engage the residents with an art and craft session. The centre celebrates most festivals, especially during Navarathri when they have groups coming to sing bhajans.



Pradeep Prasad during the workshop



At the park and (left) during the talk.

A green message gets amplified across Chennai

Rotary Club of Temple City invites two Indira Nagar residents to deliver a talk on a neighbourhood park walkers club’s “Tree Naming Initiative” at a meeting in Egmore

PRINCE FREDERICK

One should not hide one’s light under the bushel. And one cannot hide it under the bushel if it is of high and impressive radiance. A radiant “green” light is going out of Indira Nagar to other parts of Chennai.

Recently, Rotary Club of Temple City organised a talk on “Green Environment Awareness Creation

Initiative for the Public” at Presidency Club on Ethiraj Salai in Egmore. A talk-based presentation, it did not feature big names from nature conservancy collectives and NGOs. It was delivered by C. Namachivayam and K. Srinivasa Raghavan, who were gloriously introduced as members of a walking club at a Greater Chennai Corporation park in Indira Nagar. That was just their calling card that day, the

reason they were facing an audience.

They went on to give a blow-by-blow account of what they call “Tree Naming Initiative”, an exercise sustained by residents of Indira Nagar who have an abiding love for their neighbourhood park.

They decided to add the tree species at the park, located on Indira Nagar Fourth Cross Street, to their local residents directory. Af-

ter all, trees are also residents, in fact residents with a natural and greater staying power.

C. Namachivayam observes that the idea of naming the trees stemmed from a simple observation. Though they pass by the trees every day at the park, they have no idea what they are; their common names, let alone their species, are a mystery to them. Members of the walkers club decided to address

this lack of connection.

He explains: “It was proposed that name boards be installed, not for every individual tree, as there are over 150 trees, but for each species present in the park. Each board includes a photograph of the tree, its name in Tamil and English, and its botanical name. Additionally, a QR code is provided. When scanned using a mobile phone, the code directs users to a website where more detailed information about the tree is available.”

Namachivayam adds that around 40 species have been identified and corresponding boards created and installed.

Wider appeal

When Rotary Club of Temple City came to know about this initiative through one of its members, V.S. Ganesan, who is a resident of Indira Nagar, part of this park walkers’ club and closely associated with the Tree Naming Initiative, the “green” light was not going to stay hidden under a bushel.

The Rotary club was clear that the message has to go out to other residents’ groups in other parts of Chennai so that they replicate it in their neighbourhood parks.

Chennai residents, take cleanliness survey seriously now

With citizen feedback for Swachh Survekshan having begun, animators are reaching out to various groups seeking that individuals answer a set of 13 questions. Chennai is believed to have been doing poorly in this annual assessment partly due to its residents' reluctance to take the survey



Animators request a resident to take part in the survey and (right) outside a textile showroom.

LIFFY THOMAS

If you are stopped by an animator, a professional in Greater Chennai Corporation ranks, and asked to take part in a cleanliness survey of the city then do spare a few minutes for them.

The Citizen Feedback for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan is on and every input by a resident slipped into the online system will help determine where Chennai stands among cities in terms of its cleanliness quotient.

The survey is not just about rankings but improving people's quality of life, which makes public participation significant.

Citizen participation is the cornerstone of the initiative, with 35% of the total percentage of marks allotted based on what its people have to say about various initiatives taken by the city corporations. However, over the years, what has put Chennai at a disadvantage is poor residents' participation in the process.

"This time, we have set a target of reaching at least five lakh people in Chennai," says a member with the IEC team.

Animators are reaching out to college students, anganwadi staff, teachers and bulk waste generators explaining the processes that go behind this ranking and requesting them to take part in the exercise.

Two of the city's main waste management companies, Urbaser Sumeet and Ramky, are also help-

ing out in this exercise by reaching out to communities they are working with.

Citizen Feedback 2026 requires residents to answer 13 simple questions related to sanitation, waste collection, public toilets and the performance of local authorities. One has to complete the survey on their own as an OTP is generated for every submitted feedback.

Posts on its social media handles are expected to start coming once election results are out, nudging citizens to take part, says the staff.



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Field surveys under way in states and UTs

The exercise is expected to be completed by the end of May

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Field surveys for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan 2026 is under way in many states and union territories since April 25.

The annual exercise by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India, is much awaited as this is an important component of ranking cities on various parameters including sustainable sanitation and waste management.

A communication dated April

24, 2026 by Roopa Mishra, Joint Secretary and Mission Director, Swachh Bharat Mission - Urban, outlines that the number of documents required for the "Service Level Progress" component has been reduced this time to ease the burden on Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).

The assessment teams visiting various ULBs to audit work done on the ground are expected to complete their field survey by May 31, says the communication. ULB officials are required to maintain operational records in

the form of logbooks. The communication also reiterates that citizen feedback, an important component in the ranking, is voluntary and unbiased, and cities should not mobilise pre-selected groups to interact with assessors.

In order to make Swachh Survekshan more inclusive, this time MoHUA has mandated that assessors deployed for on-ground surveys be fluent in the regional language and conduct the survey in the respective language, particularly in areas where English or Hindi is not preferred.

All questions in the assessment application pertaining to Direct Observation, Citizen Validation, and Citizen Feedback will be made available in the regional language to facilitate ease of understanding and response by citizens and ULB officials.

The Swachh Survekshan was launched on December, 20, 2025, followed by sharing the toolkit and ULB trainings.

The window to update Management Information System and City Profile data for all ULBs closed on April 10, 2026.



Never mind if you have not been to Darjeeling, check out T. Senthilkumar's scale train models at the exhibition. The associate director with an MNC has tried to recreate the Himalayan town around its railway line. The engine is an exact replica of the Himalayan Darjeeling Engine which is currently running, he says. There are some 120 small parts that went into making this scale model; it took close to two years for Senthil to source those parts. The Porur resident says this hobby is a bit of a science, art and self-discovery. "I was fascinated

Cool Darjeeling comes to hot Chennai

A fascination that started in school has turned into an obsession for Porur resident T. Senthilkumar

since childhood. I design and build detailed train layouts that combine creativity, engineering and storytelling. Each layout reflects real-world railway operations, including signals, terrain

and automated train control. Through my work, I aim to inspire others to explore this fascinating hobby and appreciate the beauty of railways in a scaled-down form," he says.



Chug down the Madras of 1856

The ongoing mini train exhibition by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory concludes on May 3

LIFFY THOMAS

With the forty mini model and 20 intricate layouts, this mini train exhibition is sure to strike a nostalgia chord in every visitor.

Organised by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory from May 1 to May 3 to celebrate World Heritage Day, a closer look and one can discover the artistry, engineering and cultural significance of Railways across generations.

For the first time, the host is also among the participants. Chennai Rail Museum has showcased a mini rail project of Madras in 1856 donated by Maurice W. Roacha of Brisbane, Queensland in Australia. The Anglo-Indian, a resident of



The train project donated by Maurice W. Roacha from Australia

Chennai before migrating to Australia, is passionate about modelling trains and wanted to gift this to someone when the Museum gladly accepted it.

"In memory and gratitude to The Railway family of the bygone days, who served the Indian Railways with dignity and pride," reads a note.

The model showcases the Madras Railway Company (MRC) and the city of Madras as its background.

MRC founded in 1845, and after many years of negotiating with the East India Company and the Government of Madras, an agreement was made, to build a railway from Madras Wallajah Road and then to

Arcot with Royapuram as its terminal. A short note along with the model explains how MRC changed hands and became the Madras and Southern Maharashtra Railway and then to Southern Railway.

In its fourth edition now, the mini train exhibition has grown over the years. This time, there are hobbyists from Mumbai, Bengaluru

What, when and where

On display: Thomas train, Vande Bharat, All UNESCO Railways (Nilgiri Mountain Railway Locos, Darjeeling Himalayan Railway Locos, Katra Railway loco), New Pamban Bridge in Movement, Christmas Express and Three Tier Running Tracks

Venue: Chennai Rail Museum, New Avadi Road

Ticket cost: ₹15 for children below age 13; ₹40 for adults (The ticket cost includes a toy train ride and gallery visits)

and Cochin as well showcasing their scale models.

This event is not only a tribute to the legacy of trains but also an opportunity to inspire curiosity and appreciation among visitors of all ages. With detailed layouts, interactive displays and passionate exhibitors, the exhibition promises to be both educational and entertaining, says a note. It reflects the enduring role of trains in connecting people, places and histories, while offering a platform for hobbyists and professionals to share their craft.

An everyday utility created with metal discards

Integrating rice mill and automobile scrap material, a resident of Manimangalam panchayat creates a garbage unit that combines functionality, aesthetics and nostalgia



A view of the installation at Gurukul Street in Manimangalam; during Mattu Pongal the installation is decorated.

PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

PRINCE FREDERICK

Experiences in late childhood and early adulthood stick fast and long like cyanoacrylate, and would sometimes go on to be fodder for creativity. That is plain, observed logic. But if you are a pedant given to swallowing something only if it arrives with a saccharine coating of high-sounding concepts, here they are for you.

'Schema Theory' and 'Reminiscence Bump', both from psychology, explain this form of creativity. A 38-year-old architect displaying no signs of pedantry, M. Dilli Babu explains his *creation artistique* as

plainly as possible in any human language. "What I saw as a child I have recreated."

What did he see?

Garbage being picked by carts drawn by oxen. At panchayats in distinctly rural settings, around three decades ago, one could expect garbage being gathered in a cart pulled by an ox. Manimangalam now might be in the peri-urban bracket, but is still a village panchayat in administrative terms, and back when Dilli Babu was a child, draft animals, precisely oxen, would have been on the conservancy team.

And what did he recreate?

A functional garbage cart paired

to an ox, the whole shebang created with upcycled materials. The installation is plonked at the entrance of Gurukul Street in Manimangalam, where Dilli Babu also has his house. Garbage is dumped and cleared. The installation is a head turner, something this writer can vouch for from personal experience, having stopped to take a long look at it while on the way to somewhere else.

Six years ago, when he got started on this project, Dilli Babu sought permission from the Manimangalam panchayat to repurpose a cart lying at the panchayat office unused and in a state of oblivion.

Chewed away, the garbage col-

lection unit had to have sheets welded into it, wheels replaced. The cart was paired with a bull, and the exercise drew upon a slew of material from the rice-grinding equipment that were past their usefulness in the rice mill.

Dilli Babu's brother runs a rice mill, which made discarded materials from there the automatic choice for the sustainability project. Running a construction company named DB Architect, Dilli Babu could repurpose old construction material. Bent TMT rods define the contours of the ox. Motorcycle and cycle parts are unmistakable, despite being seamlessly blended into the *objet d'art* with efficient welding and painting. Suspension parts from a Tata 407 truck have also made a handsome contribution to the design.

Dilli Babu points out the rear section can be removed, facilitating easy garbage clearance. The cart can be lifted in a manner comparable to how a traditional cart can be

lifted and kept lifted after unharnessing the ox.

The garbage cart had a two-in-one functionality thrust into it with a 200-litre water tank being placed in the "innards" of the ox. The water could be accessed through a tap. The practice of filling the tank and offering it as an additional utility was discontinued when visitors from a Tasmac outlet nearby make the site of the garbage cart a pit stop, thanks to the availability of drinking water, says Dilli Babu.

With an explicit bovine connection, the installation is swept into Mattu Pongal celebrations every year. Prior to the event, it is not just bedecked with glitzy decorative items, but also put through a wringer of maintenance work and repairs.

The installation would have been fuelled by nostalgia, but it is nostalgia that scratches below the surface of feel-good sensation to surface something of immense everyday utilitarian value.



Kindergarteners 'graduate' at Porur school

The National IT International Matriculation Higher Secondary School and Vidhyaarsh Public School in Porur recently celebrated the 22nd Kindergarten Graduation Day.

The event was inaugurated by correspondent V. Padmavathi, a renowned sociologist and social activist, says a press release.

The chief guest C. Vinodhini, associate professor, Sri Ramachandra Faculty of Pharmacy, Sri Ramachandra Institute of Higher

Education and Research DU, Porur, delivered a thought-provoking speech, emphasising the importance of nurturing multiple intelligences and quotients in children, and also highlighting the crucial roles both parents and teachers play in a child's holistic development. Another chief guest, P. Sowmya Lakshmi, Assistant Professor, Department of Pharmaceutical Chemistry, Sri Ramachandra Faculty of Pharmacy, Sri Ramachandra Institute of

Higher Education & Research (DU), Porur, urged parents to invest quality time with their children, sharing a powerful message: "If you work on what you want, they never despair."

Vidhyaarshini Venkat, trustee of Serva Santhi Educational Trust, graced the event.

Students in graduation attire proudly received medals and certificates, their bright smiles creating a warm and celebratory atmosphere. A total of 200 Upper

Kindergarten students received graduation scrolls from the distinguished guests. The event featured compering by the students themselves, whose confidence, communication skills and teamwork impressed the audience, says the press release.

Correspondent V. Padmavathi addressed the gathering, emphasising the important role of parents and educators in shaping a child's learning journey and character.

Repair Cafe workshop next Sunday

Repair Cafe Chennai is conducting an electrical workshop at Thoraipakkam on May 10; 10.30 a.m. onwards. The session is open to all. One can bring something broken and mend it together or lend a hand in someone else's repair work.

One can register up to two items. Small electrical/electronic household items like decorative/festive lights, toaster, lamps, hand mixer and water boiler can be brought to the venue. Or, bring any such broken items so we may examine them, identify the issues, and perhaps even try to fix them, said a note.

The Repair Cafe Chennai Initiative is a Community gathering where repairers and visitors come together to mend small household items.

Fees for participation is ₹ 1000.

The workshop is happening at AJSD Academy, 2nd floor, Door No, 122/1, Balamurugan Gardens 1st Main Rd,

Thoraipakkam. For details, Whatsapp 9880712792 / 9008241414 / 9739686665

Robotics centre at Easwari College



SRM Group's Easwari Engineering College has established a Global Excellence Center for Robotics on its Ramapuram campus.

By Switzerland-based ABB Robotics, a global leader in robotics and machine automation, the facility (inaugurated recently) is the first of its kind in India.

The centre features advanced AI-enabled robotic systems and intelligent automation labs, including 3D pin-picking, palletizing, spot and arc-welding cells, service and maintenance units, and VR/digital simulation cells.

Subrata Karmakar, president, of ABB Robotics, inaugurated the centre. "Robotics and automation are revolutionizing the manufacturing sector, with industries across sectors and of all sizes rapidly embracing these technologies, especially in countries like India, where manufacturing is being strongly prioritized. It is our responsibility to equip engineering students with skills in this emerging domain, enabling them to secure high-value careers, while also encouraging interdisciplinary research and innovation to develop solutions for industry needs."



HOUSEWIVES?... STUDENTS?..

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During the awards ceremony; and (below) a view of the campus.

School bags award for environmental action

Chettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School, located within the ecologically rich 108-acre Chettinad Health City in OMR, Kelambakkam, has been recognised by Earthday.org for its commitment to sustainability practices, a milestone that reflects years of deeply rooted environmental action woven into the school's very identity.

According to a press release, founded in 2017 as a Cambridge International School offering both day and residential facilities, Sarvalokaa has long believed that education and environmental stewardship belong together.

The school operates within a Net-

Zero, All-Electric, closed-loop campus, generating 51% of its energy through solar and wind, treating and reusing 83% of its daily wastewater, maintaining zero groundwater dependency, and absorbing up to 60 tonnes of CO₂ annually through its dense native forest cover spanning 5.8 acres of native flora and a thriving three-acre mango forest.

The press release adds that the campus is entirely free of motor vehicles, operating instead through walking and cycling pathways that create a silent, clean, and healing environment for learners. A zero-waste circular ecosystem, supported by seven composting units and a strict no-plastic policy, en-

sures that the school's ecological footprint remains minimal.

But beyond infrastructure, it is the children who make this recognition truly meaningful.

From growing food seed-to-plate and caring for animals to building bug hotels, creating natural rangoli, and learning barefoot amidst nature, Sarvalokaa's learners live it every single day. The school's nature-inspired curriculum transforms the campus itself into a living classroom.

This Earthday.org recognition joins a growing list of acknowledgements for Sarvalokaa, the release adds.

For more information, visit www.sarvalokaa.org



Swetha Anand elected as president of CREGU India



The India chapter of Centro Di Ricerca Sull'Educazione Dei Giovani Per L'UNESCO (CREGU), a centre based in Italy dedicated to advancing youth education and research, has inducted Swetha Sundeeep Anand as its national president for UNESCO Youth Education Research Center in India.

The induction ceremony

was held at Bharath Institute of Science and Technology in Tambaram.

The induction ceremony was officiated by Melisa Aysegil Gal, head of the Secretariat of CREGU, who was the chief guest.

Melisa Aysegil Gal delivered a keynote address on 'Youth Voices on Sustainable Development Goals'.

Tribute to Muthuswami Dikshitar

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai Kendra, in association with Chaitanyam, is organising a programme titled "Hidden Gems in Muthuswami Dikshitar compositions" on May 3 at East Mada Street, Mylapore. Sangita Kala Acharya R.S.Jayalakshmi and Cleveland V.V. Sundaram will inaugurate the event at 9.30 a.m. This will be followed by a vocal concert by Gayathri Girish and Group. All are welcome.

Annual day celebrated



The Mangadu Public School recently celebrated its 16th annual day. Aari Arjunan, actor in Tamil cinema, and Sumathi Vaitheeswaran, president of Chikkarayapuram Panchayat, took part in the celebrations, according to a press release.

Aari gave an insightful address, highlighting the importance of discipline, hard work and continuous skill-based learning for students, and the benefits of compounding for parents.

Students mesmerised the audience with vibrant cultural performances, and the institution recognised and honoured the achievements of students and staff over the years.

Gautam Srinivas, the correspondent, and Arvind Srinivas, the school's managing director, took part.

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